

(Pitch) Museum Design, explained

A small and fashionable explainer of the first part of my TCC.

This project has two goals:

1. Actually **explain my TCC in mundane terms** so that my mom and dad and friends can read it. If there is a downside to writing a pre-project with 30 pages and 7000 words is that **obviously** almost nobody is as interested in your research topic as yourself and wants to read the entirety of it. This project makes the research digestable.
2. **Gather museum workers to contact and partner with.** There is no way museums will just let us stroll in and talk to their customers and employees if they don't know what we are doing and how serious we are taking it. This project will stack more odds in our favor.

So, everything in this project is optimized to explain and excite. Forcibly, what's exciting must help in explaining and what explain has to do it in an exciting way.

Doing the thing

This first section of the document comprehends the creative decisions that went into the project from editing the text to releasing it. The second part is all about how to publicize it, surf on its hype and revert the clicks into museums willing to collaborate with us - or even universities willing to offer us Masters to keep the research going.

Content or nothing

The first step was obviously distill the 34 pages filled with 7000 words into fewer and more approachable words. The goal was to take an academic document and turn it into something a person can read waiting for their dish at a restaurant table.

The possibility of someone finding the project and being super excited to read the academic project itself is thin but still exists and we got them covered by offering the option to download the document as a .pdf right at the beginning of the website and again at the end of it.

The process for this was opening the document with literally crossing out everything that was academical formalities and made no sense to tell a layman or prospect collaborator about. And then proceeding to rewrite the entirety of what was left.

(screenshots of my scribbles)

Metadata

None of the metadata of the document is removed from the website for one unshakable reason: morality.

The possibility of someone not understanding this is a research project part of bachelors degree is very high unless explicitly noted otherwise. In the academic context this level of polish and fun is not seen often - probably for good reasons - and specially in this historical context, is very easy to read this as an early-access website of an startup AI-empowered bullshit. If that glimpses someone's mind for even a second, we are doomed.

Introduction

The introduction here becomes an introduction of the whole website experience and not only of the content of the text. This is when we make it clear what kind of alterations we are making on the content to fit the website storytelling and to what ends.

This is also when we offer the option to also download the academic document in pdf beyond simply reading this digest.

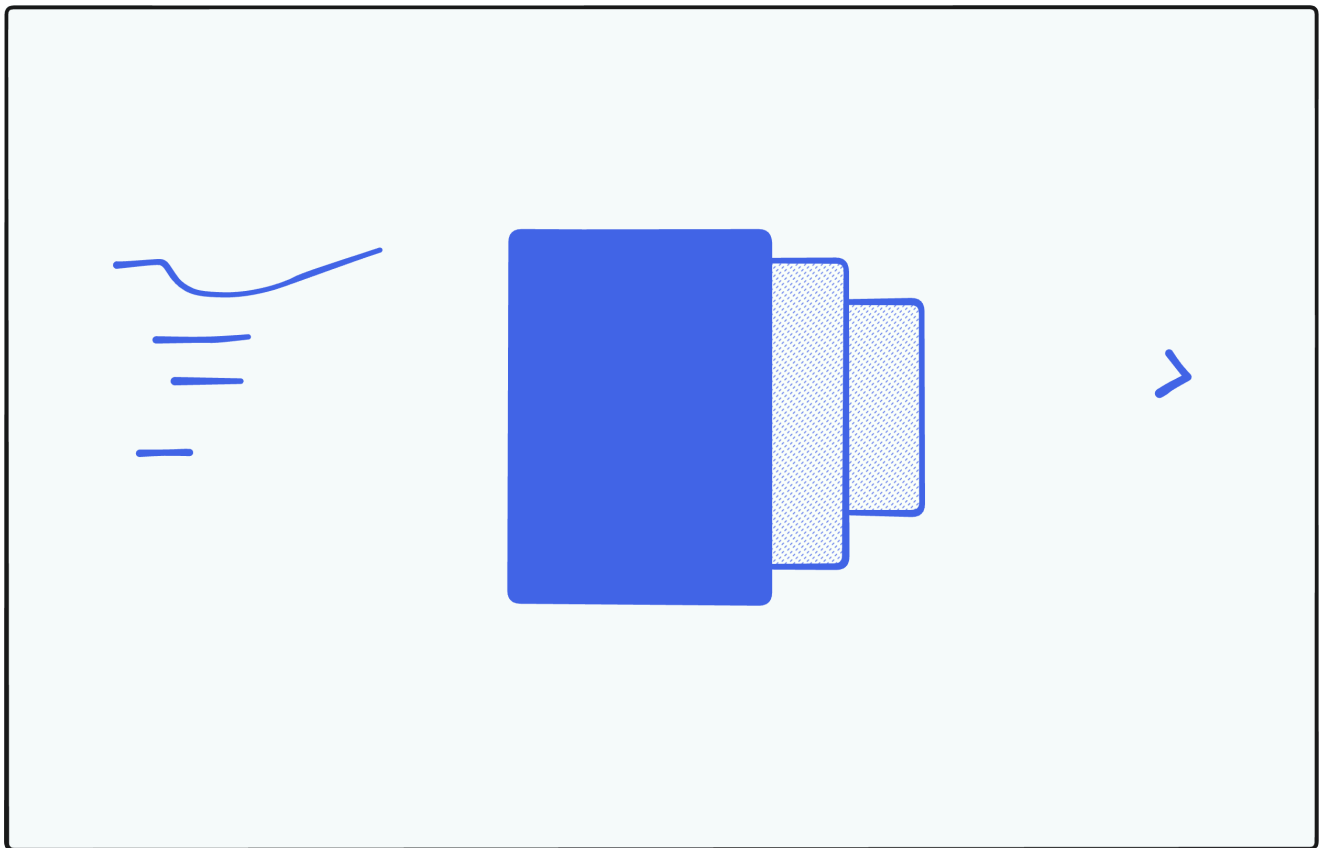
Images

Some images of the original document are removed, some are kept and some are added for storytelling. The ones that are kept don't receive any treatment and appear precisely as they are in the original document, flowing with the text.

The ones that are added receive a tint treatment with blue, the color used throughout the whole website to signify big visual changes to the document: images, data visualizations, footnotes, videos and links.

Bibliography

We make use of the beautiful covers of the books we have used to guide the research thus far and moving forward. Because they are not part of the original document we do apply a little bit of styling to them, but the remaining text is pretty similar to what is documented.



Inspiration

Schedule

Extremely reduced and simplified just for the sake of people understanding where they can help and when they can jump in. To make things more concise we intertwine this with the content in the objectives and the methodology of the work - which almost disappears due to being the more technical part of the project.

References

- **References** become footnotes and we took some inspiration from [Behind scenes of Devouring Details](#) on how to handle them.

First, someone pointed out that navigating to footnotes was mildly uncomfortable because you could not easily jump back to your previous scroll position. For the selected footnote, the platform now displays a back button.

The mobile gap connects to something from your original pitch — I think you already half-solved this. If the sidenote column disappears on mobile, where do sidenotes/footnotes go? I think the answer is *the footnote back-button mechanism you described in the pitch* — that was probably designed with exactly this problem in mind. So the pattern is likely:

- **Desktop:** sidenotes render inline in the 1/3 column, always visible, no navigation needed
- **Mobile:** sidenotes collapse into the tap-to-jump + back-button footnote flow

If that's the intent, it's worth stating explicitly now, because it means every sidenote needs to author *two* renderings (margin-note vs. jump-footnote), not one — that's an MDX component design decision, not just CSS.

And more

- **Abstracts, list of figures, list of frames and list of attachments** are all removed.
- **Summary** is replaced by an outline that follows the text on the corner of the screen.

An exhibition of our deeds

Not exploring the visual metaphor of a museum and exhibitions in a website like this felt like the loss of the century and I am not a loser. Consequently, the resulting visual theme of this website is the union of the academic paper and the web, leveraging the Edward Tufte elements to fit information nicely.

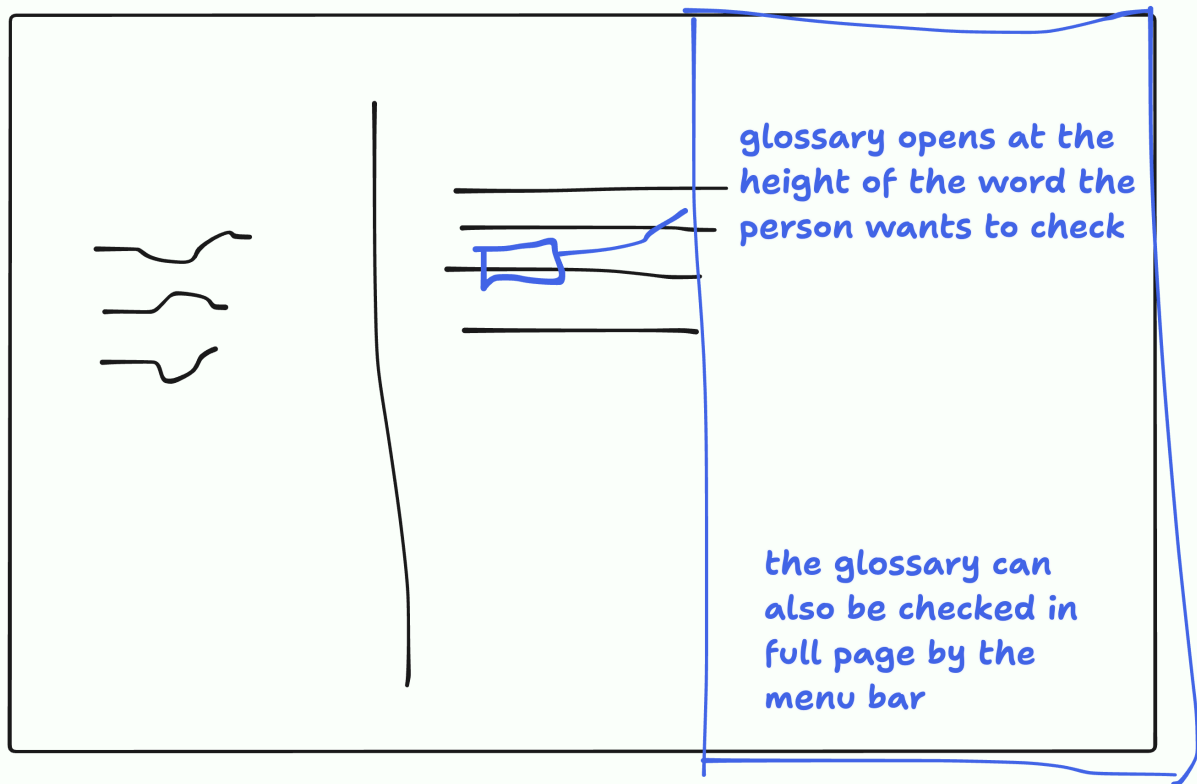
Here is a comprehensive description of the main elements we got to tell the story based on the theme of museology and research.

Glossary

The main takeaway of this whole research for us was learning a thousand new terms, people and organizations related to the world of museum. We could abstract the text to a level of palatability that doesn't have any of the weird and niche terms of museology, but that never sounded like a good idea.

We wanted the language to be more friendly and not to make our friends dumb. If you are reading a text and don't want to see any new words or phrases in it, what are you reading it for?

So we kept the words in the text and offered even more explanation if the person felt like she needed it in the glossary. This also helps a lot with the flow of text because definitions don't usually sit well in the structure of phrases.



Data

Pretty early on in the process we came across data about museums that were very trustworthy but not flexible at all. We had a lot of fun coming up with a data analysis scheme to have the data we needed but decided not to fill the academic document with graphs because we knew it wouldn't be appreciated. Here, we know it will.

A lot of information will be visualized instead of just written down and each of this visualization have a main takeaway that empowers our research. Knowing how many museums we have in our country makes you want to think more about them, knowing that half the people that enter a museum hate it makes you, a museum worker, consider ways to get better.

For this reason each of the visualizations can be exported as images or fill the link the person uses for sharing the research, so that's how the og-image will behave for that given link.

This is such a good idea that it actually isn't mine, Claude gave me it. Following goes everything Claude had to say about it.

***What it is:** one static visual, built once, carrying 3–4 of your strongest Belo Horizonte-specific numbers — 223 museums, 61.5% with educational activities, 87% free entry,

68.3% offering guided visits. Not a dashboard, not interactive — a single image that stands on its own with zero context needed.*

***Why it needs to exist outside the site:** a museum professional getting a cold email isn't going to click through into a whole interactive digest before deciding whether to reply. But they will glance at an image attached to that same email. This graphic is the thing that gets forwarded internally at a museum ("look at this") in a way the full site can't.*

***Design:** build it in the same visual language as the rest of the site — reuse the pink/yellow/black palette from your cronograma and Tufte-principles figures, and consider literally putting it inside the picture-frame motif you already described as a running metaphor. That's not extra design work, it's applying a system you've already defined to one more surface.*

Where it lives, concretely:

- *Build it as an SVG (fits your existing design system, scales cleanly)*
- *Give it a real route on the site (e.g. `/panorama` or similar) with its own OG image, so it's a link people can share too, not just a file*
- *Export a PNG version for email attachments and a downloadable version from that page — this is literally the "you can share and download the data visualization pieces individually" line already sitting in your pitch, just connected to a job*

***How it plugs into outreach:** it becomes the actual first-contact artifact — attach it directly to the email/DM, with one line linking back to the Collaborate page. The full digest becomes the thing they explore after they're already interested, not the thing that has to convince them in the first place.*

Document viewer

The image breaks the text like in the document and can be expanded both on mobile and on desktop to better viewing and understanding.

When we have more than one snap of document it emulates a pile of documents and they have a depth relationship. The pile is cyclical though behaving pretty much like a carousel.

We make use of the slimmer column on the left side to annotate the metadata of the document or a comment that we want to make about the image itself. This metadata only appears when the movement of the document in the carousel has become idle and disappears while the images flip.

Venn Diagram

Let Edward Tufte know that I know my data visualization and used it right here. This project happens at the intersection of service design, information design.

We use the Venn Diagram near the books to indicate where they locate themselves in the themes of the project, for example.

Picture frames

And the most obvious representation of a museum to me is the Frame emoji. If you talk about a frame hung on a wall, everybody kinda fills in the blanks in the corners with more frames and more walls. Although not all museums are for this and like this, we leaned on these visual metaphor a lot throughout the website.

One good example is the icon of the page being a frame with a system workflow drawn inside it. Metaphorically service design in a museum, all our research is about.

The selfish choice

One of the beautiful things of building side projects and specially starting new projects (websites, apps, whatever), is the lack of constraints on the stack. You can choose whatever language you want and framework, learn new paradigms, organize code completely differently because let's be honest, a year from now, not even yourself will be committing to this codebase.

Because of this I always bring one very selfish choice with me to every project. If this is a bad idea, there's no money or KPIs in the line and not even me will have to handle it for much time. If it does work though, I have something handy to show someone in a meeting and say: let's do it like that, I have done that's before.

The selfish choice of the day is [Shaders](#).

The closest thing to an academic paper I have read on the web is the website of [Tacit Labs](#). I wanted a similar vibe, primarily the simplicity which makes it very easy to focus on the text. Something else they have is this very subtle use of particles on the landing page, hovering it creates some dispersion on the particles. I wanted something like that happening here and shaders felt like a very fun way of filling in the frames we wanted to use as decoration.

Developing the reading experience

Stacking the odds

- **Next.js (App Router)** + MDX for content
- `next-intl` for PT/EN
- `@paper-design/shaders-react` for the hero effect
- **Route Handler + Resend** for the contact form
- **Vercel** for hosting
- Document viewer built from manually cropped screenshots (no live PDF rendering)

Packaging

- manifest.json
- robots.txt
- sitemaps.xml
- opengraph-image and twitter image
- Instrumentation
- Web Interface Guidelines

Tiny bits

- The 404 page should say "oops, {insert here} is not the theme of our research"
- You can share and download the data visualization pieces individually

Telling people

where does this get posted first, who gets the direct link vs. who finds it organically, does the process itself (like your pitch document) become shareable content the way "Devouring Details" clearly inspired your footnote UX. You're already good at writing about your own process — that could be a distribution asset, not just a design reference.